

ELEMENTS OF ART



PART 1: LINE AND SHAPE

The two elements every character is built from. Round 1 is line and shape only.

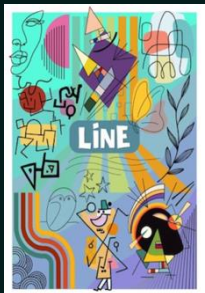
ELEMENTS 1 AND 2 OF 7



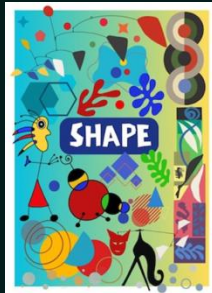


TODAY

01



02



LATER IN THE UNIT

03



04



05



06



07



The elements of art are the seven building blocks every artist and designer uses. They are not a style and they are not a rule. They are the parts every drawing is made of, including the character you will design.

We cover two at a time, and you redraw your character after each round. Round 1 is line and shape. Round 2 adds form and space. Round 3 adds value, color, and texture.



WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

OUTCOMES / 02 / 18

01

DEFINE LINE AND SHAPE

You will explain both in your own words, without looking them up.

02

NAME THE FIVE TYPES OF LINE

You will point out horizontal, vertical, diagonal, curved, and zigzag lines in real work.

03

TELL GEOMETRIC FROM ORGANIC

You will sort any shape into one group or the other.

04

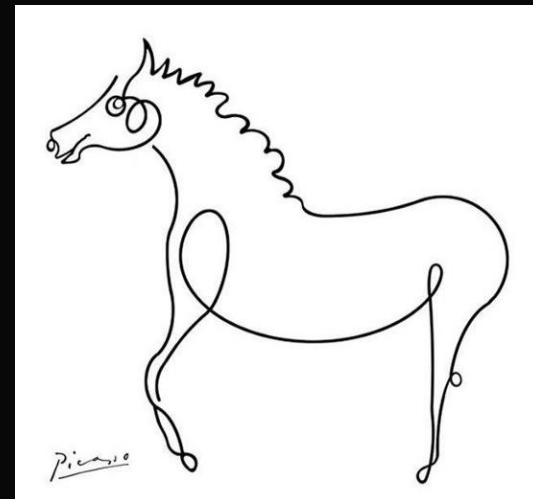
FIND THE NEGATIVE SPACE

You will see the empty areas as part of the design, not as leftovers.

05

BUILD A CHARACTER FROM BOTH

You will design an original character in your sketchbook using only line and shape.



Designers use these words every day on the job. A client says "make that line heavier" or "the negative space feels tight" and you need to know exactly what they mean.

01

ELEMENT 01 OF 7

LINE

A mark that travels. The first mark any artist makes, and the one every other element is built from.

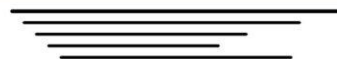
5 Types of Lines in Art

Vertical lines



Suggests height & strength

Horizontal lines



Suggests
calmness, restfulness
& stability

Diagonal lines



Suggests movement,
perspective and instability

ZigZag line



Creates excitement and intense
movement

Curved or organic line



Conveys comfort, calmness,
and curves gracefully



WHAT IS A LINE?

LINE / 03 / 18

A line is a mark that moves from one point to another. It has length. It has almost no width.

01

A LINE HAS DIRECTION

Every line goes somewhere. Which way it points changes how the work feels.

02

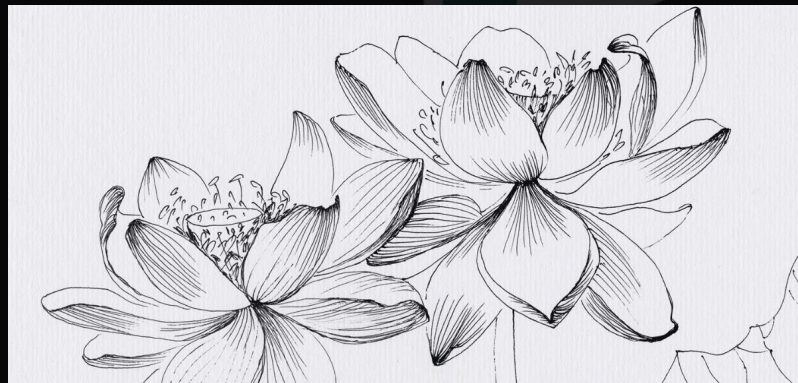
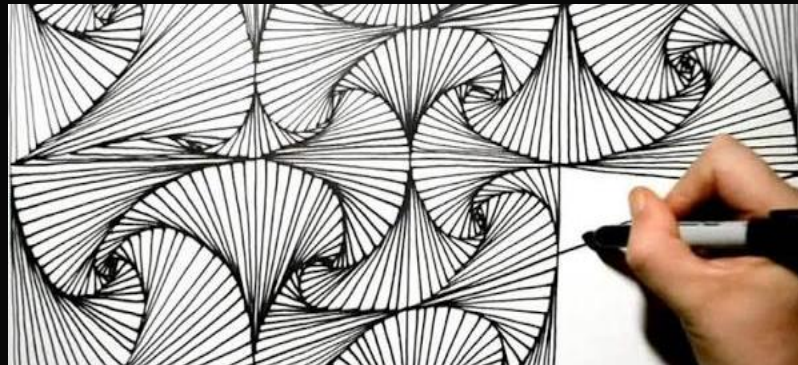
A LINE HAS WEIGHT

Weight means how thick or thin it is. A heavy line pulls your eye first.

03

A LINE CAN BE IMPLIED

Your eye connects marks that never touch. Artists use it to suggest a jaw or a cheek.





Line

A mark that travels from one point to another. It has length but almost no width.

Contour line

A line that follows the outside edge of an object and describes its shape.

Implied line

A line your eye finishes on its own, even though the full mark is not there.

Line weight

How thick or thin a line is. Heavier weight pulls more attention to it.

These four words go on your vocabulary sheet. You will use all of them in the critique at the end of this unit.



THE FIVE TYPES OF LINE

LINE / 05 / 18

01

HORIZONTAL

Lies flat, left to right. Feels calm, still, and restful.

02

VERTICAL

Stands straight up. Feels tall, strong, and formal.

03

DIAGONAL

Leans. Feels like movement, speed, or tension.

04

CURVED

Bends smoothly. Feels soft, natural, and flowing.

05

ZIGZAG

Turns sharply again and again. Feels busy, excited, or nervous.

STRAIGHT



VERTICAL



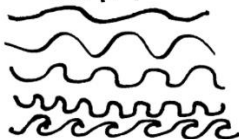
DIAGONAL



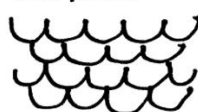
HORIZONTAL



WAVY



SCALLOP



ZIG ZAG



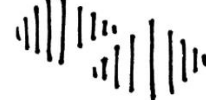
CURLY



DABBED



GRADUATED



ZIG ZAG



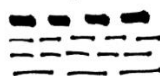
CURVED



DOTTED



DASH



CHEVRON



SPIRAL



BROKEN



THIN



THICK



CRISS CROSS





01

WEIGHT IS THICKNESS

A 0.25 pt line whispers. A 12 pt line shouts. Both can be right.

02

VARY WEIGHT ON PURPOSE

Heavier on the outside edge, lighter inside, and a flat drawing starts to look solid.

03

QUALITY IS THE FEEL

Smooth, rough, broken, or shaky. Line quality is the personality of the mark.

A BEGINNER HABIT TO BREAK

Using one weight for everything makes a drawing look flat and unfinished.



Same drawing. Only the line weight changed.



It leads the eye

A line tells the viewer where to look first and where to go next.

It divides space

A rule between two columns is a line doing organizing work.

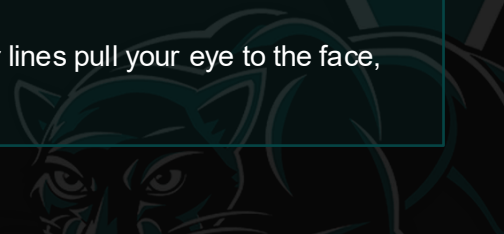
It builds texture

Many lines close together read as rough, soft, or woven.

It defines edges

A closed line becomes the outline of a shape. That is the next section.

Look at any cartoon character and you will find all four jobs at once. The outline defines the edge, heavier lines pull your eye to the face, and hatching builds texture.





WHAT YOUR LINE SAYS ABOUT THEM

LINE / 08 / 18

01

SMOOTH CURVES READ FRIENDLY

Rounded, flowing outlines make a character feel calm, safe, and likeable.

02

SHARP ANGLES READ DANGEROUS

Jagged, pointed lines make a character feel tense, sneaky, or threatening.

03

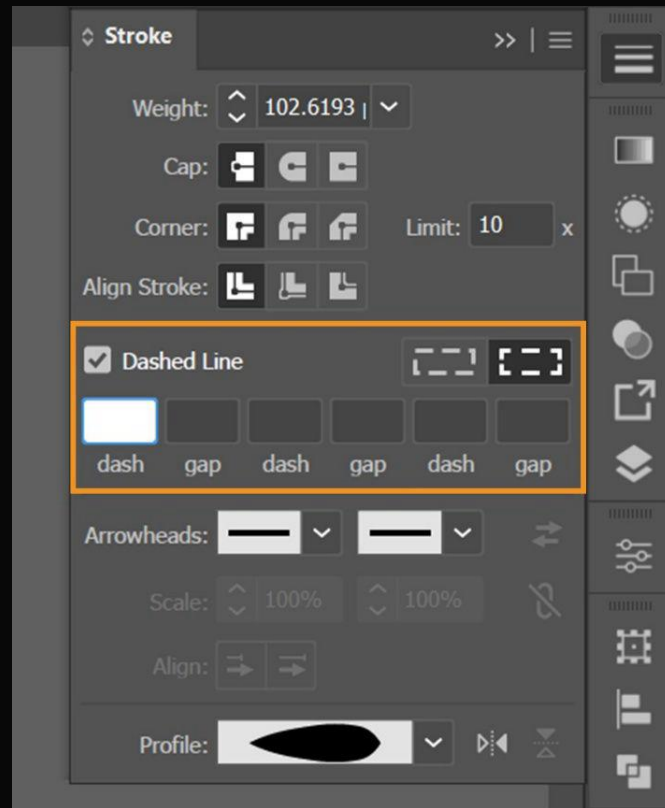
SHAKY LINES READ NERVOUS

A broken or wobbly outline suggests the character is scared, old, or unsure.

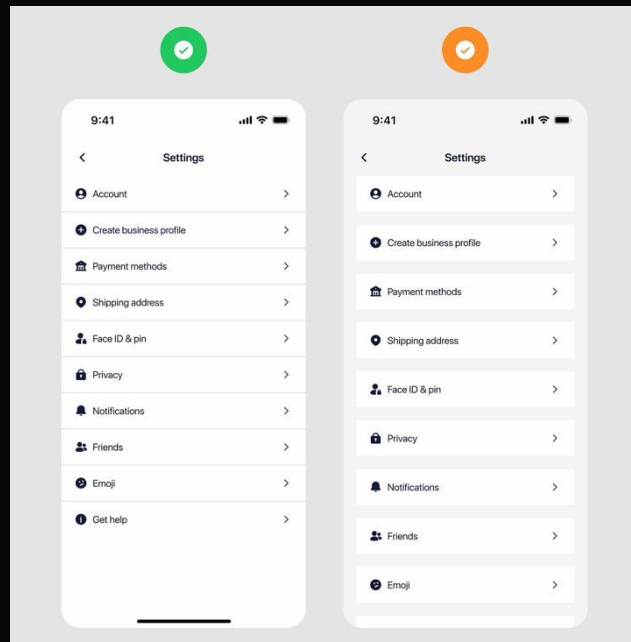
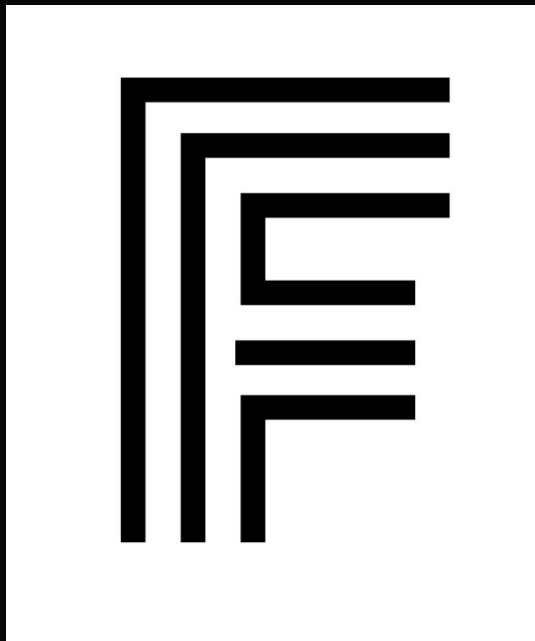
04

HEAVY OUTLINE READS SOLID

A thick outer contour makes a character feel heavy, strong, and planted.



Pick your line style before you draw.



Professional work. Look at the line weight and where it changes.

ASK YOURSELF: WHERE DOES YOUR EYE GO FIRST, AND WHAT SENT IT THERE

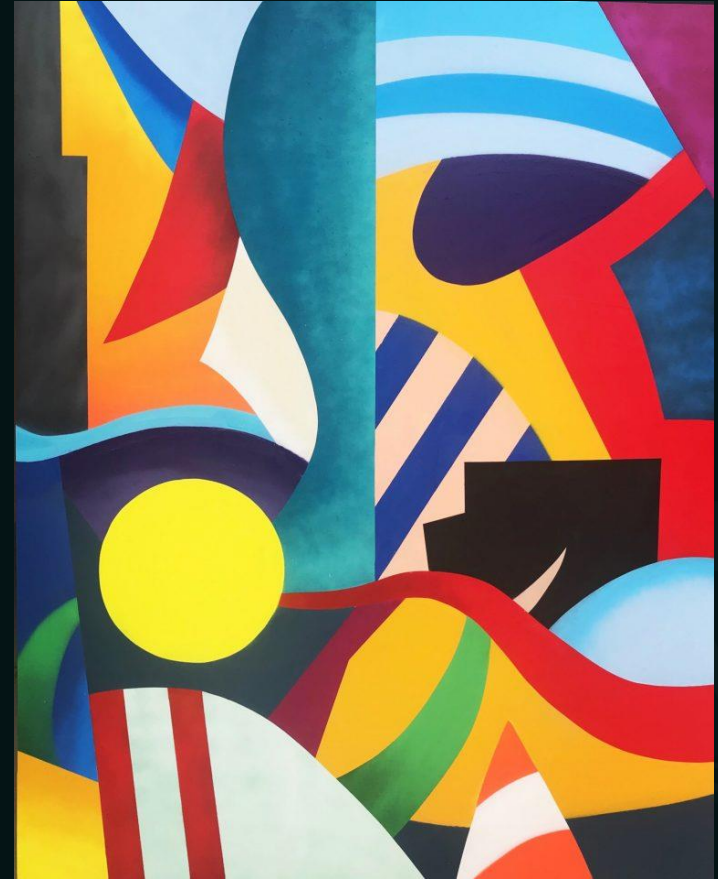


02

ELEMENT 02 OF 7

SHAPE

What happens when a line comes back around and closes. Flat, enclosed, and the base of every cartoon character you know.





WHAT IS A SHAPE?

SHAPE / 10 / 18

A shape is a flat, enclosed area. The moment a line meets itself, the space inside becomes a shape.

01

SHAPES ARE TWO DIMENSIONAL

A shape has length and width. It does not have depth.

02

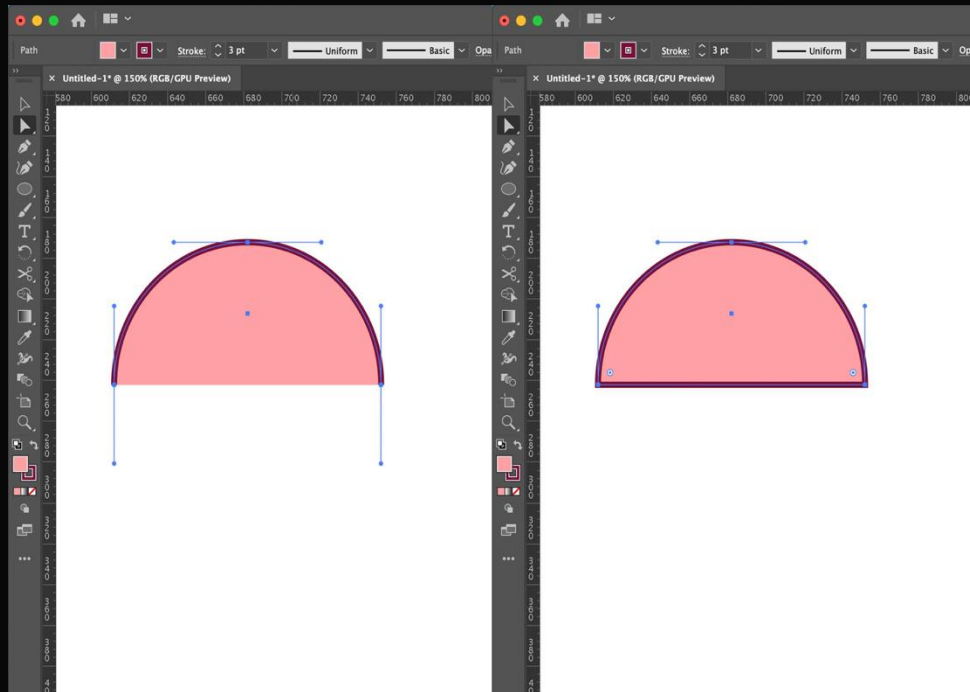
A SHAPE NEEDS A CLOSED EDGE

That edge can be a drawn line or just a change in color.

03

SHAPE IS NOT FORM

Form is the three dimensional version. Form is coming in Part 2.



Close the line and you have made a shape.



Shape

A flat enclosed area with length and width but no depth.

Geometric shape

A shape with clean edges and regular measurements, like a circle, square, or triangle.

Organic shape

A free, irregular shape. The kind you find in nature, like a leaf or a puddle.

Negative space

The empty area around and between shapes. It is part of the design, not leftover room.

Negative space is the one students skip. The gap beside your character's arm is part of the design.





Geometric

Clean edges and even measurements. Circles, squares, triangles. They feel built, ordered, and man made.

Organic

Free and irregular edges. Leaves, clouds, spills. They feel natural, relaxed, and alive.

Most characters use both. A robot leans geometric so it reads as built. A friendly animal leans organic so it reads as alive.

Neither group is better. Pick the one that matches your character. That choice is a real design decision you will defend in critique.





01

POSITIVE SPACE IS THE SHAPE

It is the object itself, the part you drew on purpose.

02

NEGATIVE SPACE IS AROUND IT

It is the empty area surrounding and between your shapes.

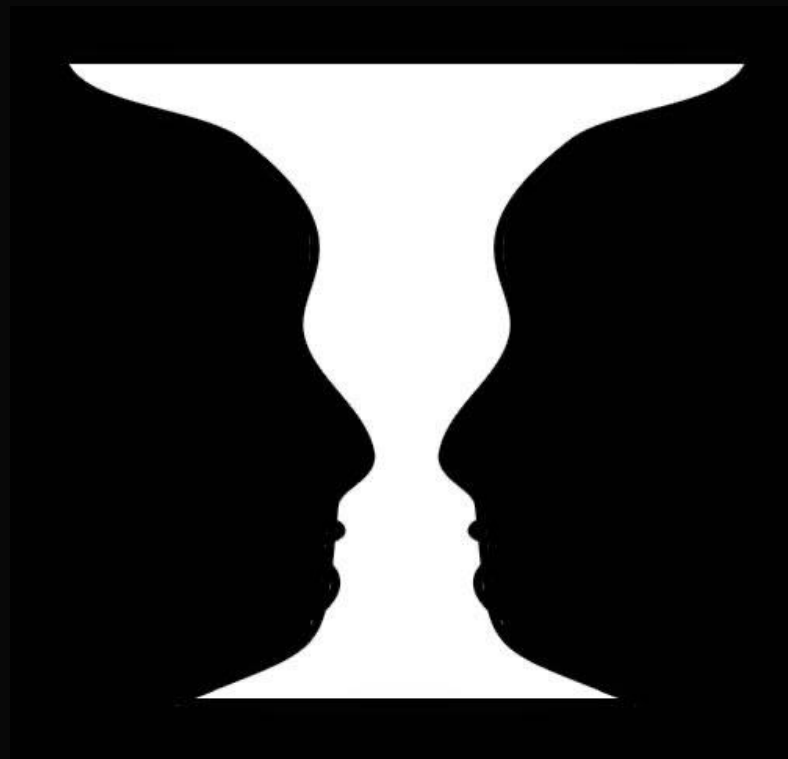
03

BOTH ARE DESIGNED

The empty part is not leftover. A good designer shapes it as carefully as the object.

THE FAMOUS TRICK

Some of the best known logos hide a second shape inside the negative space.



Look at the white, not just the black.



01

CIRCLES READ FRIENDLY

Round characters feel safe, soft, and likeable. Most heroes and sidekicks are built from circles.

02

SQUARES READ STRONG

Boxy characters feel stable, heavy, and dependable. They are the ones who hold their ground.

03

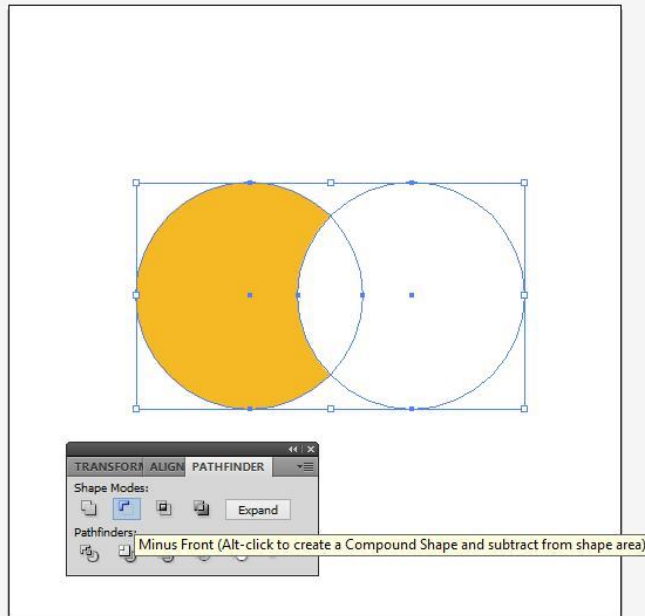
TRIANGLES READ DANGEROUS

Pointed characters feel sharp, fast, and unsafe. Most villains are built from triangles.

04

MIX THEM ON PURPOSE

Pick one shape to dominate your character, then use the other two as accents.



Choose your dominant shape before you draw.



HOW LINE AND SHAPE WORK TOGETHER

CONTENT / 15 / 18

Line and shape are not two separate topics. A shape is what a line becomes when it closes. Every character you know started as a shape decision.

Line makes the edge

The outline decides where the shape stops and the background starts.

Shape makes the mass

Filled area gives the design weight and presence on the page.

Together they read

Edge plus mass is how a viewer knows a character in silhouette.

Fill your character in solid black. If you can still tell who it is, your silhouette is working.





CHECK YOURSELF

STUDY / 16 / 18

01 NAME THE FIVE TYPES OF LINE AND THE FEELING EACH ONE GIVES.

02 WHAT IS THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN A SHAPE AND A FORM?

03 IS A MAPLE LEAF GEOMETRIC OR ORGANIC? HOW DO YOU KNOW?

04 WHAT IS NEGATIVE SPACE, AND WHY IS IT PART OF THE DESIGN?

05 WHAT SHAPE WOULD YOU BUILD A VILLAIN FROM, AND WHY?

Say all five answers out loud with a partner before you start sketching.





Line is a traveling mark

It has direction, weight, and quality. It can be implied.

Five types of line

Horizontal, vertical, diagonal, curved, and zigzag.

Shape is a closed area

Flat, two dimensional, and made when a line meets itself.

Geometric or organic

Clean and measured, or free and natural. Most work uses both.

You also know negative space is designed on purpose, and that shape language tells a viewer who your character is before they read a word.



COMING UP IN PART 2

NEXT MINI LESSON

Part 1 was flat. Part 2 adds depth. You will redraw your character with volume, then learn how the space around them works.

Element 03: Form

What happens when a shape gains depth and becomes three dimensional.

Element 04: Space

Foreground, middle ground, and background, and how depth is faked on a flat screen.

Bring your vocabulary sheet and your Round 1 character. Part 2 is Round 2.

